Broken Child

By Marcia Cameron

(NOTE: Paragraphs are Marcia's narration as an adult looking back on her childhood – Her flashbacks are noted as character's speaking (ex MARCIA:))

I couldn't make the blood stop. It was everywhere. I got in my car to escape. As I drove I kept taking my hands off the steering wheel to wipe the blood from my eyes. I made an instantaneous decision. Enough. I could do no more, stand no more, be hurt no more. I unbuckled my seatbelt, closed my eyes, and pressed the gas pedal to the floor. "Let me die. Just let me die!"

INTRODUCTION

The autobiographical narrative, Broken Child by Marcia Cameron takes us on a harrowing, unforgettable journey into the nightmare of parental abuse and the darkness of mental illness. As a way of coping with daily abuse at the hands of her mother, Marcia Cameron's created Emily, an alternate personality who from the age of three became her constant companion. Broken Child by Marcia Cameron.

Lying in a hospital bed in walked a tall man

DOCTOR: "My name is Dr. Williams . . . smashed femur . . . fractured lumbar . . . . "

Struggling through pain and drugs I spoke the only thread of thought in my mind "Please let me die. I beg you." Dr. Williams held my hand.

DOCTOR: "Marcia, how did you get all those fractures I saw on the X-rays? You have many . . . "

MARCIA: "I don't know."

Nothing made sense. The year was 1982, I was forty-one, and my mind was in chaos. All my adult life I have lived what I felt was a charade. I was a great actress playing a role covering up for the missing on the clock, living with unexplainable fears and panics, fighting

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suicidal impulses, and battling depression. I had a childhood I kept trying not to remember . . .

My first memory of abuse was the closet. I spilled milk all over the table and in a rage my mother dragged me to the closet under the front stairs. My mother struggled with my flailing arms and legs as I screamed "NO, Mommy, no! I'll be good! I'm sorry I spilled my milk! She shoved me into the blackness of the closet. I screamed and screamed, throwing my whole body against the door. The blackness was encompassing. I felt I couldn't breathe. I have no way of knowing if I was there for minutes or hours. At three and a half it seemed forever. My mother opened the door. I looked at her in defiance

MARCIA: "Just wait until Daddy gets home and I tell him what you did to me!"

My mother grabbed my arm and dragged me up the stairs to my bedroom, she threw me on the bed, she tied my arms and legs to the posts of the bed. Her wild eyes were looking at me but not seeing me . . .

MOTHER: "You are a wicked little girl. If you ever tell anyone about what I do to you I will give you away to the gypsies. The gypsy men will tie you to their wagons and they will hurt you. And you will never see daddy again. You must never tell anyone I hurt you."

I writhed against the kerchiefs binding me and screamed and screamed and screamed.

MOTHER: "You must not tell" . . .

When daddy came home I did not say a word. Abuse breeds more abuse. The closet became a more regular occurrence. In the long hours of silence and imagination Emily, my imaginary escapist friend, became more real to me. She could fly, breathe under water, she could even dare to be angry. One time I was put in the closet for what seemed an eternity. I worried that I had been forgotten. I wet my pants. My stomach cramped and I doubled over in pain . . . I used to corner to defecate . . . I sat in the stinking black closet and waited and waited.

EMILY: "I'm here! We can't stay here. It stinks."

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MARCIA: "We can't go, we have to stay here"

EMILY: "She's mean to leave us in here. There is nothing to do. It isn't fair. I'm getting really mad. You know what? Let's go play with the ca-ca in the corner. Let's put it on the walls and let mommy know how mad we are."

MARCIA: "NO! We can't do that. She'll hurt us."

EMILY: "I don't care"

Emily went up to the pile of feces in the blackness I watched in fascination as she smeared and painted all over the walls getting it in our fingers and hair. Letting it cover us in angry satisfaction.

When the closet door opened, mom let out an angry yell

MOTHER: "What a truly evil child you are!"

MARCIA: "Emmy did it, mommy. I'm sorry. She did it."

MOTHER: "Now you're even a liar!"

She shoved me back into the closet.

MARCIA: "See, Emily, being angry just makes it worse"

EMILY: "It was worth it"

And that began our lifetime of differences. Emily couldn't help me in moments of intense physical pain. No fantasy could take away the pain. There was the old enema bag I hated. My Mother would strip off my clothes and put me in the empty tub. Then she would run hot water into my while I sobbed.

MARCIA: "I'm sorry I'm evil, mommy. I don't mean to be bad. Stop! Please stop! It hurts! I'll be good I promise to be good!"

The pain got so intense . . . I learned to focus on the gold drain, hunched in agony, pretending I was going down, down the drain into blue water where I was free.

There were many nightmares; nights I didn't sleep, nights when physical pain kept me awake. One day while trying to help set the table I dropped the cream pitcher and it exploded in a spray of glass. Mom dragged me up the stairs and tied me to the bedposts

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again. She left the room for what seems a hundred years. My mother came back with straight pins. As I lay immobilized in my tied up position, she took pins and stuck then through my labia as though I were a thanksgiving turkey. She untied me and left the room. The pins still sticking through my parts and the ends of the pins stabbing into my left thigh. I couldn't see the pins to take them out. Getting stabbed harder with each move, I waddled to the bathroom mirror. I saw the drops of blood spread on the white hexagonal tiles. I was crying in great hiccupping sighs, as I pulled out the pins one at a time.

My body healed faster than my mind. The terrorizing continued. I lived in constant pain. It was part of my life. I still tried not to provoke violence. No one in the world tries harder than an abused child . . .

MARCIA: "I must not talk loudly. I mustn't laugh. I mustn't run in the house. I mustn't spill things. I must never be angry."

Some things I accepted. Because I was evil, I must be burned, cut, hit, and locked up. My sense of abandonment was the most intense I had ever experienced. I was alone-terrifyingly frighteningly alone. I couldn't even escape in fantasy. I was deeply depressed.

I walked onto the balcony overlooking the cement driveway. The only thought was a compelling need to escape . . .

EMILY: "Let's leave"

MARCIA: "I wish I could fly like you. I would fly away. No one loves me,"

EMILY: "It's easy just flap your arms real hard and you'll go up, up into the sky. You're right. No one loves you."

MARCIA: "Will you help me fly?"

EMILY: "Sure! I'll go with you. We'll never come back."

I climbed onto the railing of the balcony, looking up at the sky. I do not remember consciously choosing to die . . . merely to leave what I could not tolerate anymore. I stood on the rail flapping my arms, determined I would fly away. I took a giant leap off the rail and plunged head first from the second story balcony. I felt no fear as I fell, merely a

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fascination that flying didn't work. I never told anyone I jumped off the balcony on purpose.

My story is one of child abuse in the extreme, and the multiple personalities I created to deal with the pain. The cost of child abuse is a story that needs repeating until every baby born is cherished and safe. Writing this story will be worth the effort if even one abusive parent reads this and seeks help. It will be enough if one more hurt human being feels there are answers to the inner pain. Maybe like all authors I am inspired to write so like footprints in the snow, someone will know I lived. . . Not well, but I'm here.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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